the church's reliance on too-simple truth. He revised the *Theologia* twice, coming up with its final form in 1135; he assembled a whole collection of quotations from the church fathers that contradicted each other into a work called *Sic et Non* (Yes and No); he wrote a series of dialogues about ethics between a Christian, a Jew, and a character called the Ancient Philosopher; the *Collationes*, in which the Ancient Philosopher shows a clear understanding of the Highest Good—despite having only natural law to guide him.[6]

He was often accused of heterodoxy, potentially dangerous departures from orthodox, accepted understandings of the Christian faith. At least once, he was briefly imprisoned. But the help of powerful patrons, and the enthusiasm of his many students, kept him from out-and-out condemnation by the Church—until 1141, when the revision of the *Theologia* drew the attention of none other than Bernard of Clairvaux: venerable in character, conspicuous for learning, evangelist for the Second Crusade.

The two men were polar opposites: Abelard determined to bring faith and logic together, Bernard holding the authority of the Church above all. "He had an abhorrence of teachers who put their trust in worldly wisdom and clung too much to human argument," Otto of Freising explains. When, in 1140, a local monk sent Bernard a letter highlighting Abelard's most recent doctrinal explorations, Bernard agreed that the matter required investigation.[7]

He asked Abelard to come and explain himself; Abelard instead appealed to the Bishop of Sens, and then to the pope. Probably he believed that his own skill in argumentation would help him to triumph. But it was exactly this skill that frightened his traditionalist opponents: "Peter Abelard," wrote Bernard, in his own appeal to the pope, "believes he can comprehend by human reason all that is God."[8]

To give Abelard a pass was to accept the categories of Aristotle; and accepting Aristotelian thought might well throw into doubt the entire authority structure of the Christian church. In 1141, the papal court agreed with Bernard. Abelard was to be imprisoned and condemned to perpetual silence. The sentence doomed him to pass the rest of his life without words: confined in a monastery, forbidden to speak, making his wants known only with signs.

In the eyes of his followers, the silencing of Abelard was a tacit acknowledgement that Aristotelian thought was both powerful and true. "The high priests and Pharisees convened an assembly," wrote his student Berengar of Poitiers, using a New Testament metaphor for Bernard and the papal court, "and said: What should we do, since this man speaks of many wonderful things? If we let him go on like this, all will believe him." But for Bernard of